in unfavourable terms.[2] Maxwell[3] said in a 2014 interview that Kissinger had read *India's China War* in 1971, when it came out in America, and that

> it changed his thinking on China, and he pressed the book on [President] Nixon—all that's on the record now, in the transcripts of Nixon-Kissinger-Mao [Zedong] talks [1971–2]. While Kissinger was in Beijing, Zhou Enlai sent me a personal message to tell me that Kissinger had said to him, 'reading that book showed me I could do business with you people'.

But the more I read about the conflict, the more I came to realize that Maxwell's version of the events leading up to the 1962 War did not stand up to any serious scrutiny. First of all, Nehru's Forward Policy, which was designed to secure the entire Sino-Indian frontier from Ladakh in the west to the North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA; an administrative unit under the government of Assam and now the Indian state of Arunachal Pradesh) in the east, was decided upon at a meeting in New Delhi on 2 November 1961, less than a year before the war. Nehru chaired the session, which was also attended by Defence Minister Vengalil Krishnan Krishna Menon, head of the Intelligence Bureau, Bhola Nath Mullik, Foreign Secretary M.J. Desai, and the then newly appointed Army Chief of Staff, General Pran Nath Thapar.

It was obviously an important meeting at the highest level. However, rather than being an aggressive measure, the instruction to the army was to 'patrol as far forward [in Aksai Chin, Ladakh] as possible from our present positions. This will be done with a view to establishing our posts which should prevent the Chinese from advancing any further and also dominating any posts which they may have already established in our territory.'[4] The new outposts that were set up in the eastern sector above the plains of Assam were manned by relatively small contingents of poorly equipped personnel, mostly from the paramilitary Assam Rifles.

Rather than India provoking China, it could be argued that it was the new communist leaders of China who had behaved aggressively after they seized power in 1949. In 1950, they sent thousands of troops to invade Tibet, a de facto independent nation. For the first time in history, India shared a common border with China without Tibet functioning as a buffer between the two civilizations.

In the mid-1950s, the Chinese also built a highway through Aksai Chin, an area claimed by both India and China. But the area was evidently controlled by the Chinese, as it took almost a year for the Indians to